MENTAL WELLBEING



Significant anxiety and depression are associated with increased postoperative pain, prolonged hospital length of stay, and hospital readmission, as well as many other postoperative complications. [1,2]

Preoperative education and expectation setting can help reduce postoperative anxiety, depression, and length of stay, and improve patient experiences and outcomes. [3,4]

Screening Tools

The Patient Health Questionnaire-2 (PHQ-2) is an initial screening tool for depression, comprising the first two questions of the Patient Health Questionnaire-9 (PHQ-9). A PHQ-2 score of 3 or more warrants completion of the PHQ-9. [5,6]

The General Anxiety Disorder-2 (GAD-2) is an initial screening tool for generalized anxiety disorder (GAD), comprising the first two questions of the General Anxiety Disorder-7 (GAD-7). A GAD-2 score of 3 or more warrants completion of the GAD-7 scale. [7]

While no scale is diagnostic, these tools are intended to help identify pre-surgical patients who may be experiencing more significant symptoms, who may benefit from targeted pre-surgical intervention.

Patient Health Questionnaire (PHQ-9)

OVER THE **LAST 2 WEEKS**, HOW OFTEN HAVE YOU BEEN BOTHERED BY ANY OF THE FOLLOWING PROBLEMS?	NOT AT ALL	SEVERAL DAYS	MORE THAN HALF THE DAY	NEARLY EVERY DAY
1. Little interest or pleasure in doing things	0	1	2	3
2. Feeling down, depressed, or hopeless	0	1	2	3
3. Trouble falling or staying asleep, or sleeping too much	0	1	2	3
4. Feeling tired or having little energy	0	1	2	3
5. Poor appetite or overeating	0	1	2	3
6. Feeling bad about yourself — or that you are a failure or have let yourself or your family down	0	1	2	3
7. Trouble concentrating on things, such as reading the newspaper or watching television	0	1	2	3
8. Moving or speaking so slowly that other people could have noticed? Or the opposite — being so fidgety or restless that you have been moving around a lot more than usual	0	1	2	3
9. Thoughts that you would be better off dead or of hurting yourself in some way	0	1	2	3

SCORING PHQ-9

This is calculated by assigning scores of 0, 1, 2, and 3 to the response categories, respectively, of "not at all," "several days," "more than half the days," and "nearly every day." PHQ-9 total score for the nine items ranges from 0 to 27.

0-4: Minimal depression
5-9: Mild depression
10-14: Moderate depression
15-19 Moderately severe depression
20-27: Severe depression

Developed by Drs. Robert L. Spitzer, Janet B.W. Williams, Kurt Kroenke and colleagues, with an educational grant from Pfizer Inc.
No permission required to reproduce, translate, display or distribute.

Generalized Anxiety Disorder Questionnaire (GAD-7)

OVER THE **LAST 2 WEEKS**, HOW OFTEN HAVE YOU BEEN BOTHERED BY ANY OF THE FOLLOWING PROBLEMS?	NOT AT ALL	SEVERAL DAYS	MORE THAN HALF THE DAY	NEARLY EVERY DAY
1. Feeling nervous, anxious, or on edge	0	1	2	3
2. Not being able to stop or control worrying	0	1	2	3
3. Worrying too much about different things	0	1	2	3
4. Trouble relaxing	0	1	2	3
5. Being so restless that it is hard to sit still	0	1	2	3
6. Becoming easily annoyed or irritable	0	1	2	3
7. Feeling afraid, as if something awful might happen	0	1	2	3

SCORING GAD-7 Anxiety Severity

This is calculated by assigning scores of 0, 1, 2, and 3 to the response categories, respectively, of "not at all," "several days," "more than half the days," and "nearly every day." GAD-7 total score for the seven items ranges from 0 to 21.

0–4: minimal anxiety

5–9: mild anxiety

10–14: moderate anxiety

15–21: severe anxiety

Source: Primary Care Evaluation of Mental Disorders Patient Health Questionnaire (PRIME-MD-PHQ). The PHQ was developed by Drs. Robert L. Spitzer, Janet B.W. Williams, Kurt Kroenke, and colleagues. For research information, contact Dr. Spitzer at ris8@columbia.edu. PRIME-MD® is a trademark of Pfizer Inc. Copyright© 1999 Pfizer Inc. All rights reserved. Reproduced with permission

MENTAL WELLBEING ALGORITHM

Complete both the PHQ and GAD questionnaires to assess risk of depression and anxiety.

PHQ-2
Score ≥ 3
Complete PHQ-9

Score 5-18

- ▶ Patient Education
- ▶ Self-Referral Options
- ▶ Physician Referral to mind-space.ca

Score ≥ 19

OR Yes to self-harm thoughts
Urgent referral to Psychiatry or Primary Care

GAD-2
Score ≥ 3
Complete GAD-7

Score 5-14

- ▶ Patient Education
- ▶ Self-Referral Options
- ▶ Physician Referral to mind-space.ca

Score ≥ 15

- ▶ Referral to Psychiatry or Primary Care
- ▶ Referral to mind-space.ca

Clinician tips on Reframing Benefits vs. Emphasizing Risk

The language clinicians choose can meaningfully shape patient experience. During informed consent or risk discussions, framing recommendations in terms of benefits - rather than focusing solely on risks - can foster reassurance and engagement.

- Risk-focused framing:

  "Your history of anxiety/depression increases your risk of greater pain, longer hospital stay, readmission, and other complications.

- "Benefit-focused framing:

  "Your answers to the screening questions show me that you've been feeling some worry and/or low mood. Many people feel this way before surgery. Taking care of your mental wellbeing can help you to feel more calm, comfortable, and in control. It can help you to heal more quickly and more easily."

Patient Education

- Set patient expectations for postoperative depression and anxiety management
- Refer to online patient resources

Self-Referral Options

- Encourage patient to seek help from at least one of the following options
  - Primary care appointment to discuss mental health (provide patient with their PHQ-9 and GAD-7 scores)
  - Help Starts Here or 211 for online/telephone access to local supports and resources
  - 310-6789 BC mental health and crisis response line
  - 988 national suicide crisis helpline
  - BounceBack BC - a free, online skill-building program to manage low mood, mild to moderate depression, anxiety, stress, or worry (ages 13+)

Physician-Referral Options

- Mild to moderate symptoms
  - Mind Space Referral (mind-space.ca)
  - PHQ-9 score 5-18, and NO thoughts of self-harm
  - GAD-7 score 5-15
  - Patients require an active primary care provider. Referral can come from PCP or perioperative clinician as long as patient has a PCP.
- Severe/Urgent Symptoms:
  - GAD-7 >=15 OR PHQ-9 score >19 OR YES to thoughts of self-harm
  - Assess immediacy of risk, urgent referral to psych via ER if necessary
  - Otherwise urgent referral to primary care for assessment/psychiatry referral